

Hey, everybody. Welcome to your chapter 12 review. In this episode, we'll talk about the assessments related to posture, movement and performance. Now, if you listen to the Chapter 11 episode, I'm going to repeat myself here and just reiterate how important assessments are to the process of training clients. As a fitness professional, those assessments are your first impression of the client and their first impression of you. As well as collecting critical stats and observations, it's the first step in creating rapport and hopefully, a long-term professional relationship with a person who is going to rely on you to lead the way.

By the end of this chapter, you should be able to identify the rationale for using posture, movement, and performance assessments; identify the steps for conducting and interpreting results from the assessments; and summarize the use of fitness assessments as a tool to build rapport and credibility with clients. So that, my friends, is your high-level overview. Shall we dig in?

Posture, movement, and performance assessments are key components of the intake process for every single client. The results from these assessments are going to greatly increase your ability to develop customized fitness programs to enhance a client's well-being and improve their movement quality and efficiency. Static posture is the positioning of the musculoskeletal system while the body is still, whereas dynamic posture represents what happens to that alignment when the body is in motion.

It's important to maintain good posture and alignment in order to decrease stress on bodily tissues and joints. Keep in mind, however, that some individuals may have muscle imbalances due to trauma or a sedentary lifestyle. If that's the case, previous assessments should have clued you in on this.

When working with a client for the first time, it is a good idea to gain an understanding of their static posture, as many deviations noticed from static assessments will also occur during movement assessments. During a static posture assessment, you are looking at the five kinetic chain checkpoints. Starting at the feet and traveling up to the head, you will observe the client's posture from anterior, lateral, and posterior views, looking for neutral alignment, symmetry, balanced muscle tone, and common postural deviations.

There are three common postural distortion patterns to look for during a static postural assessment. These include pes planus distortion syndrome and both lower and upper cross syndrome. Pes planus distortion syndrome is characterized by flat feet, knee valgus, and adducted and internally rotated hips. With lower cross syndrome, you'll see an anterior pelvic tilt and excessive lordosis of the lumbar spine. And upper cross syndrome will expose itself through a forward head and protracted or rounded shoulders.

Once you're aware of the characteristics of each postural distortion pattern, you'll find you notice them all around you in people you see in your daily life, as well as the gym. The overhead squat assessment is your first dynamic assessment, and it'll serve as the basis for any other movement assessments you perform. Arguably, it's one of the most important assessments you can do with your client because it assesses dynamic posture, core stability, total body mobility and neuromuscular control.

It should further reinforce the observations made during the static postural assessment, and give way to any further insights about the client's movement quality by exposing any muscle imbalances or movement impairment patterns that could increase injury risk and/or decrease performance. From the anterior view, look for feet turning out or knees caving in. From the lateral view, look for low back arching, excessive forward lean of the torso, or arms falling forward. Recognizing these potential movement impairments will be essential to designing client-centric programming, as well as providing a point of reference to track progress in clients' movement capabilities over time.

And again, you'll get really great at picking up the common impairment patterns that tend to occur during this assessment, although you're probably not going to see these in everyday life as much unless people are randomly doing overhead squats in the street. Either way, as a fitness pro, you'll use this assessment to determine which muscles may need additional stretching and which muscles may need additional strengthening to improve and correct muscle imbalances and less-than-ideal movement patterns.

Keep in mind, poor performance on this assessment can be discouraging for a new client. So remember to always keep a positive approach when explaining to them the benefits of correcting the issues you found.

Next up, the single leg squat assessment should be used for clients that did well with the overhead squat assessment or if you feel that single leg exercises are something you might consider using in their programming. This test is a good assessment of the ability to balance, which is an important functional consideration for daily activities and exercise programming.

The single leg squat is considered an advanced movement assessment, so it should only be performed on apparently healthy clients who don't pose a significant risk of falling. As you observe the client from the anterior view during this one, the big thing you're looking for is knee valgus, which is the knees caving in. You're also going to use pushing and pulling assessments to evaluate function of the upper extremity and concurrent core stability. They can be used as an intake assessment or as an integrated part of the actual programming you design.

Again, there are specific movement impairments you'll be looking out for, including low back arching, shoulders elevating, or head jutting forward. Each of these movement impairments indicate potential muscle imbalances that can be improved and corrected using stretching and strengthening techniques. You're also going to have some clients who are looking to improve athletic performance or meet specific fitness goals.

For this crowd, you'll use performance assessments, but only after static posture and movement assessments are completed, in order to assure the safety of your client. Performance assessments are used to assess athleticism or to establish specific fitness measures, including maximal strength, power, muscular endurance, and agility. There are a whole slew of performance assessments, but let's go over some of the more commonly used ones.

You have the Pushup test, which measures muscular endurance of the upper extremities. Then you have bench press and squat strength assessments, which measure maximal strength capabilities. Those are advanced tests for strength-specific goals and may not be suitable for clients with limited experience in resistance training.

There are vertical jump and long jump assessments to measure lower body power. The lower extremity functional test, or L-E-F-T, or LEFT, is designed to test multi-direction speed and agility. This one is also considered an advanced assessment and looks at speed in relation to performance-specific goals.

Another speed assessment is the 40-yard dash, which will assess reaction capabilities, acceleration, and maximal sprinting speed. And finally, the Pro shuttle, or 5-10-5, as we call it. That one is used to assess acceleration, deceleration, agility, and control.

Not all of these will be the right assessment choice for every client. As a fitness professional, you should only conduct assessments that relate to the client's specific fitness goals, needs, and abilities.

Something else to consider here is proper sequencing of fitness assessments. This is important to help minimize skewed results. Non-fatiguing, low physical exertion assessments should be conducted prior to assessments that require physical exertion. And of course, you should absolutely always use caution when you're implementing movement and performance assessments.

There will be certain populations, like youth, older adults, prenatal women, and clients who are overweight, that may need to modify or avoid certain movement and performance assessments. By the same token, some assessments won't be applicable because they don't relate to the client's goals. It almost goes without saying, but safety comes first. So the best thing you can do is understand the sequence and usefulness of these assessments. Get to know your client, and then use your best judgment to proceed through the process.

It all boils down to this for any client to achieve a fitness goal, they must be able to move. So posture, movement, and performance assessments are key components of the intake process. As I said in the beginning, it's extremely important to establish those baselines for your clients. These findings can be used to measure and track progress, as well as help you develop an exercise program perfectly tailored to each individual's health, fitness, and performance goals.

And remember that your interpretation of assessment results is just as important as the sequence and type of movements you choose. By understanding the rationale behind each kind of assessment, you'll have a real advantage in how you work with and for your clients. And that's kind of the key, right? You're working on behalf of your clients. The purpose of your results is to establish your client's baseline so you can get them where they want to go. Think about how you can use the posture, movement, and performance assessment process as a tool to also build rapport and credibility with your client.

On the note of credibility, I'll close things out by telling you a little secret. One of the biggest pieces of feedback we hear from clients, and one challenge they have, is that sometimes they feel their trainers don't reassess them often enough. They might be good with an initial assessment. But things change over time, and it's critical for you to check in periodically to see if what you're doing is actually working or if you need to make modifications to the program.

The added value is, if the client is on track, achieving results and moving in the direction of their goals, then that just highlights your value and helps validate they've made a good decision by working with you. And with that, I'll leave you to your studying. Be well, and keep up the great work.